More than a Match

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Teen And Up Audiences

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No Archive Warnings Apply

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Catra/Glimmer (She-Ra)

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More than a Match

by YanaSapphic

Summary

Prince Catra is challenged to a duel for the title of his Left by someone he knows very well... a particular mage from Brightmoon.

Notes

This was originally a work intended for Glitra Week 2021 (oof, where did all those years go???). It's one of my favorite Glitra pieces, so I took the time to clean it up and post it finally. Enjoy!

See the end of the work for more notes

The Story Proper

Prince Catra D'riluth woke to the distinct staccato rhythm of a messenger knocking at his door. The Prince did not move or stir from his position in bed, but simply sighed and waited for the messenger to declare their intent.

"Missive for Prince Catra, summons to the royal sparring fields to stand for a Duel of the Crescent!"

Catra groaned in bed and threw a hand over his eyes to shield from the dim morning firelight seeping in from the windows. With reluctance, he slowly slipped from bed and began getting ready for the day.

Prince Catra D'riluth had refused a knight all his life and today would be no different.

It was an older tradition of Halfmoon more than it was a necessity these days - every royal family member was supposed to be assigned a personal retainer for their protections. But, with the stability of prolonged peace, the danger to the D’riluths had lessened enough that the tradition wasn’t necessary.

Still, by law, any knight or skilled combatant with a name could demand to be given a test by the Prince for the title of his Left. And when that happened, which was rather often, Catra’s test of choice was always the same: a Duel of the Crescent.

Specifically, against himself.

Because if anyone was going to be 'protecting' Catra, they should at least be as skilled in combat as themself. And in the countless individuals who had challenged them over the last two plus decades of Catra's life, winning a single bout against the Crown Prince was indeed a very rare trait. And none had managed to score enough bouts against Catra to ever win the title.

Thankfully, his mother, Queen C'yra the second of Halfmoon, had never been particularly pushy about the subject, beyond what was necessary by custom. After especially embarrassing bouts for potential retainers, the queen would even laugh quietly along with Catra as the knight retreated in shame back to the town they came from. So a new potential knight was always entertaining, at the very least, and made for a good show.

And according to the messenger that had arrived at Catra's room, today would be another such performance.

This new challenger was news to the Prince, but not particularly surprising. He had skipped a handful of court meetings - he preferred training with his WarCat and the other knights over a stuffy courtroom - so he likely missed the official challenge presented before the Queen.

And since this was the third one this week - a record high - the Prince didn't bother reading the full royal summons left pinned to his door as he waltzed out of his rooms before beginning their morning routine.

Today, that included a few short hours of personal training and drills with several of his chosen swords, followed by a handful of instructional drills with the knights of Halfmoon, and then several long minutes taken in leisure to feed and pet his WarCat, Melog.

By then, it was well past the half of day and time to report for his summons.

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"Catra D'riluth, the Prince of Nine Swords and Heir to Halfmoon," the herald announced.

The Prince walked onto the sandy field, coming to a stop in front of a long wooden rack with nine slots in it, six of which were filled. He hefted the remaining three swords off his shoulder that he brought with him and went about arranging his weapons neatly in their correct order.

Catra had a rule - utterly self imposed. For any duel, they'd start on the right of the rack and make their way left. Each time they lost a bout, they'd switch swords, moving steadily left. It wasn't so much a handicap as it was a personal challenge for the Prince. No one had made them use all nine swords in one duel, much less even three.

So it was no wonder that no challenger was worthy of their Left - Catra demanded that any knight match Catra in points to a draw or win five bouts.

A dozen paces away, standing on a platform next to a set of stands, the herald continued their announcements as more people filed into the arena. "Her Majesty, Queen C'yra D'riluth of Halfmoon."

Catra flicked an ear and a glance over his shoulder toward his mother, as she strolled onto the field, with numerous attendants and court officials in tow. He received a smile and a pleasant ear flick in return, before turning his attention back to his swords.

Their arrangement had to be perfect - it was as much a declaration of themself as it was a tactical decision. Did they place the largest of the nine, a weighty zweihander - made for them in the Crypto Mountains by the Duchy of Dryl - first? It always made for an impressive show, but its weight would certainly eat into their stamina so early into a duel. Put it too far back and they might never get the chance to use it. The options abounded.

"From Brightmoon, Glimmer Moon, Sorcerer of Mysticor."

Catra paused in his reflection, turning towards the source of the announcement. He wasn't aware anyone was coming from Brightmoon - a full week's travel by goat cart - much less the sparkly mage herself.

They spotted Glimmer in an instant, striding onto the field from the outer courtyard entrance. Instead of the usual flowing lavender and pink dresses that were the hallmark of the

Brightmoon mage, Glimmer wore a well fitted shirt and pants, much the same as Catra's in everything but color. Curious, Catra put aside their sword arrangement, and began walking toward the sorcerer, tail swaying with interest.

"Come to watch your favorite Prince win a duel?" Catra greeted once he was a few paces away, crossing his arms as a smirk steadily grew on his face.

"Not exactly," Glimmer replied, stepping away from the rest of the Brightmoon entourage. Giving them a glance over, Catra recognized the usual attendants that accompanied Glimmer, but noted that she had come without her headmage and father, Micah. "I've grown tired of seeing your pointlessly easy matches."

"Then I'm afraid you're going to be disappointed today," Catra said, nodding his head slightly to the sorcerer in greeting. Glimmer returned the gesture with a nod of her own. "Another knight has come to challenge me it would seem."

"Oh I doubt that, my dear. I have a feeling today will be *much* different." Glimmer said, matching Catra's smirk, and rolling up the sleeves of her shirt until they were neatly cuffed at her elbow.

"And why is that? I haven't lost a duel yet." Catra mused.

Glimmer didn't answer them, instead, sauntering past the Prince and toward their rack of swords. Catra followed her, no less amused by the sorcerer's antics. She paused in front of each one, regarding them with a look the Prince couldn't quite make out. After passing by the ninth sword, the mage turned back around.

"Is your order set for the day?"

"Um.. no, I think it's not," Catra replied, a small smile growing in place of the smirk form before. There were few people he told the explicit details of his sword rituals to and out of that short list, Glimmer was the only one outside of Halfmoon to know. But that conversation had taken place over a year ago and he had certainly not expected the sorcerer to remember.

"Then what will be your first choice?" Glimmer asked, walking down the line of weapons and stopping part way through. "What about your Scorpion Daggers? Tell me about those."

Catra stepped closer, coming alongside their friend. Glimmer had her hand extended toward the pair of blades, in request. Catra nodded and gestured for her to continue.

"I've told you their story before." He commented as the sorcerer turned one of the sheathed blades in her hands, admiring the jeweled arachnid symbol carved into the hilt.

"Perhaps I might like to hear it again?" Glimmer said without looking up, testing the weight of the blade.

"Very well." The Prince was always happy to indulge Glimmer with one of their stories.

Catra began to recount the tale of how he was gifted those blades by the D'ream family for defeating a pair of gigantic tremor worms that were plaguing their home city in Frightmarch.

As they did, the rest of the guests and dignitaries filed in, filling the stands at the side of the sandy field. As far as entertainment in Halfmoon went, watching the Crown Prince duel was certainly up there as the most enjoyable form of entertainment for the majority of Halfmoon's royalty.

By the time the herald sounded again, the Prince was only halfway through the story - he hadn't even gotten to the first tremor worm yet.

"The duel will now commence!" A series of notes followed as the Herald continued with the announcement.

"That's my cue," Glimmer made a pleased hum, passing back the dagger to Catra and turning to leave.

"I suppose it is," Catra replied, accepting the blade and brushing their fingers over Glimmer's hand. Their eyes met for a moment.

"Enjoy the duel."

"Oh I will." Glimmer winked once then walked away.

Catra had been so enveloped in his story - and in truth his audience of one - he hadn't heard the announcement of *who* his opponent was going to be. But, as Glimmer sauntered to the far side of the field and *not* to the stands, it dawned on the Prince exactly what he had missed.

The Crown Prince barked out a laugh.

"Is this a serious challenge?" Catra's deep voice easily carried across the field.

The pair hadn't truly sparred since they were kids, their separate choices of disciplines - magics and martial - completely unsuited to sparring past their early teens.

Glimmer, who was being handed something by two of her attendants, stopped and turned to shout back. "Someone ought to put you in your place!"

Sparing a glance to the stands, Catra caught their mother's gaze, where she sat at the top, separate from the rest. They leveled their mother a questioning look, flicking both their ears in question of whether the Queen had sanctioned this. This kind of duel was unorthodox at the very least, and there were already several whispers going through the crowd. Their mother flicked her ears forward and gave a small smirk in affirmation of her approval.

Well then.

Nodding once, Catra took a long look around the field - including at his opponent and friend - before turning back to his weapons.

"Alright Sparkles," Catra chuckled to themself, making a last minute switch to their line up. The Scorpion Daggers went into

the second slot - while they were a favorite, Catra wouldn't play into Glimmer's ruse so easily.

For his first weapon, there was a clear choice. Glimmer was fast - Catra had seen her training with her father on summer excursions to Brightmoon. Even for all his prowess and decades of training on Glimmer, Micah could never match how fast and fluidly Glimmer could move, flowing in and out of the Weave as she teleported with deadly grace.

Catra would need to match that speed with their own agility, and there were few weapons they were better at wielding with finesse than the Crescent Rapier. They had received the blade as a gift from their mother when they turned eighteen and it had been in their family for five generations. It was the first weapon the Prince had truly mastered and was easily their second favorite of the nine.

Pulling the blade and its sheathe from the rack, the Prince smoothed a hand gently down the length of the weapon, feeling its presence and all the memories he had made with it. He took a slow breath and nodded to himself. This was the right choice.

Catra turned on his heel and strode out to the center of the field.

Awaiting him were two individuals.

The first was Glimmer; she held a tall bo staff loosely in her hands and her stance was nearly as casual as it was confident. The weapon had intricate symmetrical runes carved into it, mirrored on either side of the staff's midpoint. The Prince had watched as - for several hours - his friend had carved and cast each rune with exacting detail in the sweltering heat of Brightmoon’s principal moonforge. Catra remembered the fiercely proud look Glimmer had given him when she placed the last one, completing her own bespoke magical focus. She’d been training for a decade at rune carving for that one exact moment.

There was a similar look on Glimmer’s face now.

The second person stood sternly to Glimmer's side. She was a tall magicat, wearing the formal colors of Halfmoon. Her long since grayed mane was tied expertly above her head, and her wisened and lined face was a familiar sight to both contestants.

“Mara,” the Prince said in warm familiar acknowledgement.

The old Magicat hummed agreeably. Mara spared a glance to each of them. “Reminds me of old times when I’d catch you two kits breaking into the armory for any chance to fight each other.”

The old quartermaster was a well known and respected magicat amongst Halfmooners and had been one of Catra’s first tutors when he was young. And since the Prince and Glimmer were near inseparable whenever she visited from Brightmoon, Mara became de facto trainer and babysitter to them both.

“Been a while since then, hasn’t it?” Glimmer smiled fondly at the older Magicat. “It’s good to see you again."

“Likewise child,” the elderly quartermaster placed a hand on each of the contestants shoulders, giving a firm squeeze to both.

Catra let the moment hang, savoring the fond memories of friendly banter turned into wrestling and back again. And of all the ways they spent their childhood with their closest friend. From the fond smile on Glimmer's face, the Prince hoped she was thinking something similar.

"So," Catra said, turning his attention back to the present. There would be time for more reminiscing later. "Is this a friendly match or are you applying for the post as my personal knight?"

Dying tradition or not, Catra was not about to rob his dear friend of the chance.

"The latter, my Prince." Glimmer smirked, low and confident. It was a look Catra would never tire of seeing on the mage - it fit her too well.

"I know you're quite capable - there isn't a need to prove that to me in a duel." Catra continued, knowing Glimmer couldn't resist the bait.

"I'm not looking for a handout, Catra." Glimmer growled, bearing her blunt teeth. The Prince hummed a pleased tone at that - it was a trait the mage had picked up from spending so much time in Halfmoon around Catra and other magicats. And for a non-magicat, she did a decent job of imitating the sound too. "I'm going to show you and everyone here that I am your *match* ."

The Prince's eyes went wide at the additional implications of Glimmer's words. Ones he certainly wouldn't mind exploring at another time. "Alright then. I accept your challenge, Glimmer Moon."

"Good." Glimmer replied, slamming her staff into the ground.

A moment passed as they held each other's gaze, neither willing to break eye contact or blink first.

Mara looked between both of them and cleared her throat to bring their attention to her. When she spoke next, it was to them both and the crowd several dozen paces away in a bellowing voice that bellied her age.

"For this duel, in addition to the Rules of the Crescent, the Sorcerer is forbidden from using projectile magics. Do our duelists agree?"

"Yes" "Agreed" they both shouted in unison.

Catra's eyes flicked over the mage, taking her in. That ruling would still leave the Sorcerer with all her teleporting and illusion tricks. The Prince had expected as much once they knew they were fighting Glimmer - it would go a long way to evening the playing field, but would still leave her with the mobility edge in the fight. The thought delighted the Prince - a challenge at last.

Mara nodded slowly. "And, Prince Catra, do you accept this challenge for the honor of your name and the title of your Left?"

Catra's eyes snapped from Mara to his friend. Glimmer was already tensed to begin the first bout, her mouth a thin line of determination. Catra couldn't help but smirk at her - that fire was what had cemented their friendship in the first place and the Prince had always loved seeing it flare within the mage - even when directed at himself.

Catra lowered their left hand to the hilt of their sheathed rapier, stance widening in the process. Their eyes were locked on Glimmer's, her pretty lilac orbs already burning with the intensity of her magic.

"I do," the Prince said simply.

Mara took three large steps backwards and turned to address the crowd. Continuing in her booming voice she addressed the stands directly.

"In accordance with tradition, this Duel will be held in nine bouts, one for each stage of the moon."

A tight silence was cast over the arena, the echoes of Mara's voice dying out. The Prince and the mage held the other's gaze, waiting.

"Begin!"

Lore Notes: The Nine Swords

Chapter Notes

> Added the lore surrounding Catra's swords because it was requested! 💖

The Prince's Nine Swords are a rotating set of sword and sword adjacent weapons that the Prince of Halfmoon is said to have mastered the martial form of. This was a tradition established by Prince Catra, rising to fame primarily because of Catra's skill with any bladed weapon, and at having achieved the *Crescent Rapier* at the youngest age possible of eighteen. There are nine swords because nine is a sacred number to Halfmoon representing the nine phases of the moons of Etheria. It has thus become a part of Catra's titles to be called the *Prince of Nine Swords* or the *Nine Sworded Prince.*

In addition to the Prince's whim, diplomacy also plays a large role for adding, removing, and order of the Nine. It is often seen as an honor to have the Crown Prince of Halfmoon, best swordsman in the land, fight with a weapon that your clan or city has made.

While all the weapons of the Nine are unique from each other, the weapons themselves are not necessarily one of a kind. Many are simply well crafted versions of what would ordinarily be handed to a soldier from a particular nation.

Listed below are the Nine Swords as they appeared in this fic, including their order.

1. ***Crecesant Rapier* from Halfmoon -** The Rapier is a thin blade made for agile combat and is *the* signature blade of Halfmoon royalty as many Magicats favor agility and grace and have a strong dueling culture (as seen in the fic). The Crescent Rapier is a mark of office and achievement, given to

the best fighter in all of Halfmoon which can only be claimed after winning 9 x 9 duels (81 in total). The D'riluths have kept it within their house for five generations. It marks Catra as the Halfmoon equivalent of Knight-General and he is the youngest ever recipient of the blade at just eighteen.

2. ***Scorpion Daggers*** **from Frightland -** a pair of unique curved dagger blades from the D'ream family's heirloom collection who have strong ties to the D'riluths of Halfmoon. They feature a jeweled arachnid carved into the hilt and are wielded in reverse grip.
3. **Halfmoon Pata (Indian Gauntlet Sword)** - these weapons were originally designed for use by Magicats who lacked or lost their claws, but gained popularity and became the staple weapon for WarCat riders because they are short and protect the wielder's wrist from harm while riding
4. **Naginata from Brightmoon -** A long polearm with a curved, single edged blade at its top; this weapon is designed to keep an opponent at a greater range than a sword traditionally would. It is favored in Brightmoon, as fighting cultures there have changed alongside the heavy preference towards magics. Many Brightmooners prefer to delay their opponents or keep them at a greater distance so that they might call upon a mage to assist or cast a spell themselves.
5. **Zweihander from Dryl -** This massive two handed sword shares some properties with polearms because of its weight and size. It is considered an exotic choice to many Halfmooners and is unheard of in their larger military. This Drylite Zweihander appears very mechanical in nature and includes (unused) mounting points and actuators that would normally slot into the war suits common to the Drylite military. It is often joked that none but the Prince can lift this weapon in Halfmoon on their own. That is only mostly true.
6. ***The Sword of Protection*** **(I e. She-Ra's sword, a longsword) -** A once ceremonial sword that represents the *Peace of Etheria*, a treaty signed by several Etherian nations to commit to each other defensively and economically as a peace agreement, it is styled in the manner of the sword owned by the She-Ras' of old. Catra had this blade reforged

into an actual weapon after an assassination attempt against Queen C'yra as a symbol of his commitment to peace. It is said that any who seek to break the alliance must first seize this sword after defeating the Prince in battle. That has never occurred.

7. **Ji (Chinese Dagger Axe) -** TBD
8. **Urumi (Indian Sword Whip) -** TBD
9. **Scimitar (Curved Sword)** - TBD

End Notes

Comments and Kudos are always welcome! 💖

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!